

1 Corinthians Part 1

A 50 Minute Teaching Script

BIG IDEA The crucified Christ overturns worldly measures of wisdom, power, and status. Church leaders are servants, the church belongs to God, and every believer belongs to Christ.

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: How do we decide whether a church or Christian leader is successful? Under it write: How does the cross change the way Christians evaluate wisdom, leadership, maturity, and success?

0:00-5:00 Opening question prayer and transition

Good morning. During our two lessons from Thessalonica, we studied a young church facing pressure from outside and confusion inside. Today we arrive in Corinth, where the pressure is different. The Corinthians are gifted, confident, and impressed with wisdom, status, eloquence, and strong personalities. Their confidence has not produced maturity. It has produced rivalry.

Let us begin with the question on the board: How do we decide whether a church or Christian leader is successful? What measures come to mind - attendance, programs, money, speaking ability, community reputation, doctrinal precision, spiritual gifts, changed lives, or something else?

Allow several answers without evaluating them yet. Then say: Our controlling question is how the cross changes the way Christians evaluate wisdom, leadership, maturity, and success.

Let's pray. Father, free us from boasting in ourselves and from using your servants to build our own status. Teach us the wisdom of Christ crucified. Give us humility to examine ourselves, gratitude for those who serve your church, and love for the people who belong to Christ. Amen.

5:00-11:00 Corinth and the church's beginning

Corinth stood on the narrow land bridge joining mainland Greece to the Peloponnese. Its ports connected trade toward Asia and Italy. Rome had rebuilt it as a colony, and it became the capital of Achaia. It was prosperous, diverse, mobile, and highly conscious of social rank. Wealth, ancestry, education, patrons, and public speaking could all raise a person's standing.

We should not repeat every sensational claim made about Corinth. Some jokes about 'Corinthianizing' and some temple stories describe the older Greek city rather than the Roman colony Paul knew. We do not need exaggeration. First Corinthians itself shows a church affected by sexual disorder, lawsuits, social inequality, rivalry, and pride.

Ask one reader to read Acts 18:1-11. Aquila and Priscilla arrived after Claudius expelled Jews from Rome. Paul worked with them, reasoned in the synagogue, faced opposition, received encouragement from the Lord, and remained in Corinth for about eighteen months. God formed this church through displaced workers, ordinary labor, hospitality, contested preaching, and persistent ministry.

Apollos came later. Acts 18:24-28 describes him as an eloquent and knowledgeable Alexandrian Jew. Priscilla and Aquila taught him more accurately in Ephesus, and he then ministered fruitfully in Corinth. His eloquence was a gift. The problem began when believers used different leaders and gifts as a ranking system.

11:00-18:00 Called by grace but divided

Before Paul mentions the quarrels, notice 1:1-9. He calls this troubled congregation sanctified in Christ, called to be holy, enriched by grace, and sustained by a faithful God. Grace does not cause Paul to ignore sin. Grace gives him the foundation from which to correct it.

Ask the reader to read 1:10-17. Chloe's household has reported quarrels. People are saying, 'I follow Paul,' 'I follow Apollos,' 'I follow Cephas,' or 'I follow Christ.' Cephas is Peter's Aramaic name.

Scripture never says Peter visited Corinth. A late second-century tradition from Dionysius of Corinth connects Peter and Paul with the city, but that is tradition, not direct biblical evidence. The Corinthians may have known Peter personally, known his reputation, or used his name as a symbol of authority.

We also cannot be certain that these were four formally organized parties. In chapter 4 Paul says he has applied these matters to himself and Apollos for their benefit. The slogans may identify exact groups, representative examples of party spirit, or some combination.

ASK What do you think? Are these four exact factions, representative slogans, or both? What leads you to that conclusion?

Whatever the exact structure, Paul makes the central problem unmistakable. They are using Christian leaders as badges of superiority. Paul replies: Is Christ divided? Was Paul crucified for you? Were you baptized in Paul's name? Baptism joins us to Christ; it is not a trophy proving that our Christian pedigree is better than someone else's.

18:00-28:00 The cross overturns worldly wisdom

Ask the reader to continue with 1:18-25. Crucifixion represented shame, weakness, and defeat. No culture looking for visible power or impressive wisdom would invent a crucified Messiah as its winning message. Yet God chose the cross as the means of salvation.

Paul quotes Isaiah 29:14 about destroying the wisdom of the wise. He is not attacking education, intelligence, careful reasoning, or good communication. Human wisdom fails when it believes it can discover salvation on its own, judge God's actions by its standards, or improve upon Christ crucified.

Jews demanded signs and Greeks looked for wisdom. Paul proclaimed Christ crucified. The same Christ who appeared weak is God's power; the message that appeared foolish is God's wisdom. The cross exposes our instinct to believe that impressive people, winning strategies, or cultural influence can accomplish what only God can do.

Paul then points to the Corinthians themselves. Not many were wise, influential, or of noble birth by the world's standards when God called them. God chose the weak and lowly so that no one could boast before him. Christ became their wisdom, righteousness, holiness, and redemption.

In 2:1-5 Paul explains that he did not make eloquence or human wisdom the foundation of his ministry. He did not preach carelessly. He refused to make performance the source of the gospel's power. If faith rests on the personality of a speaker, a more impressive personality can always come along and replace him.

This helps explain the Apollos issue. Acts says Apollos was eloquent. Paul does not criticize him for that gift, and 1 Corinthians 16 shows that Paul wanted him to return to Corinth. Paul and Apollos were coworkers. The congregation manufactured the rivalry.

ASK What measures of success become less impressive when placed beside Christ crucified?

28:00-35:00 God's wisdom and Corinthian immaturity

Paul is not opposed to all wisdom. In 2:6-16 he speaks of God's wisdom revealed by the Spirit. The spiritual person is taught by the Spirit and receives what God has revealed in Christ. This is not an elite Christian who has graduated beyond the gospel into secret knowledge.

Ask the reader to read 3:1-4. The Corinthians think they are mature and spiritual. Paul points to observable evidence against their claim: jealousy and quarreling. Their knowledge and gifts have not produced humble, loving conduct.

We should handle this carefully. Paul is not inviting us to look around the room and identify all the spiritual babies. He gives the church a mirror. Wherever rivalry, jealousy, and personality-centered factions govern us, we are behaving immaturely regardless of how much theology we know.

That includes teachers. It includes elders. It includes the person holding the lesson script. So the question is not, 'Who here is immature?' The question is, 'Where do our loyalties, rivalries, and desire to win reveal that we still need to grow?'

ASK What evidence of immaturity does Paul actually name? How can we use his words as a mirror rather than a weapon?

35:00-43:00 Servants builders and God's temple

Ask the reader to continue with 3:5-9. Paul asks, 'What, after all, is Apollos? And what is Paul?' They are servants through whom the Corinthians believed. Paul planted, Apollos watered, but God made it grow.

Their work mattered. Each had an assignment from the Lord and each would answer for his labor. But neither man owned the field or produced spiritual life. Christian leaders are servants, not rival franchise owners.

Paul then changes the picture from a field to a building. Christ is the foundation. Others build upon him, and the coming Day will test the quality of their work. The fire in 3:10-15 is God's future evaluation. A painful church crisis may expose fruit now, but it is not the fire Paul specifically describes.

Read 3:16-17 and 21-23. Here 'you' is plural. The congregation together is God's temple, and God's Spirit dwells among them. Damaging the unity and holiness of the church is therefore serious. Paul then reverses their slogans. They say, 'I belong to Paul.' Paul says Paul, Apollos, and Cephas are gifts to you; you belong to Christ; Christ belongs to God.

Here is the leadership principle: leaders do not own the church, create its growth, or replace its foundation. They serve in God's field, build on Christ, and answer to God for the quality of their work.

43:00-47:00 Faithful stewards and cross-shaped ministry

Chapter 4 completes the portrait. Christian leaders are servants of Christ and stewards of what God has entrusted to them. The essential requirement is faithfulness. Popularity and criticism are not meaningless, but neither gives the final verdict. The Lord does.

Paul then uses sharp sarcasm. The Corinthians act as if they have already arrived and begun reigning, while the apostles appear weak, dishonored, hungry, and mistreated. Their picture of successful Christianity has no room for the shape of the cross.

Paul does not shame them because he enjoys winning an argument. He addresses them as beloved children and calls them to imitate a life shaped by Christ. Healthy leaders point people toward Christ, treat ministry as stewardship, credit God for growth, protect God's people, accept accountability, and serve even when service costs them.

Many churches know what happens when loyalty to a personality becomes stronger than loyalty to Christ. We do not need to name people or relitigate a church's history to hear Paul's warning. Every leader and every congregation needs the same cross-shaped scorecard.

47:00-50:00 The Gospel Then and Now

Return to the board. How does the cross change the way Christians evaluate wisdom, leadership, maturity, and success?

The Corinthians ranked leaders and one another according to eloquence, wisdom, status, and visible success. The gospel answered that the church was created by a crucified Savior. Human boasting had no place. Paul and Apollos were servants. God gave the growth. The congregation was God's field, God's building, and God's temple. Every believer belonged to Christ.

We create similar tribes around favorite pastors, theological camps, politics, worship styles, programs, education, wealth, and church size. The goal is not to keep every political or theological side equally annoyed. The goal is faithfulness to Christ, whose cross will challenge the pride and assumptions of every tribe.

Here is the lesson in one sentence: The Corinthians asked which leader gave them the greatest status; Paul answered that every leader is a servant, the church belongs to God, and every believer belongs to Christ.

Before next week, read 1 Corinthians 5-7. Mark the problems involving church discipline, lawsuits, sexuality, marriage, divorce, and singleness. Keep asking: What problem is Paul addressing, how does the gospel answer it, and what faithful response does he require?

Let's pray. Lord Jesus, you were crucified for us, and we were baptized into your name. Forgive our boasting, rivalry, and desire to build status from your servants. Give our leaders faithfulness, give your church maturity and love, and keep us firmly built upon Christ. Amen.

FINAL LINE Every leader is a servant, the church belongs to God, and every believer belongs to Christ.